

July 15, 2026

Professor Matthieu Guitton, PhD

Editor-in-Chief

*Computers in Human Behavior*

Laval University

Québec City, Québec, Canada

Dear Professor Guitton,

We are pleased to submit the revised version of manuscript CHB-D-26-04350, “Help Converts Newcomers, Not Veterans: Generalized Reciprocity and Platform Engagement on Stack Overflow,” for which we received a major-revision decision. We thank you, the Associate Editor, and both reviewers for the careful and constructive assessment of our work.

The revision responds to every reviewer point; a detailed point-by-point response accompanies this letter. In brief, we (i) report matched-pair bootstrap confidence intervals for the pooled treatment effect, replacing our earlier claim that clustering was unnecessary; (ii) re-estimate the model under broader helping outcomes (comments, edits, and their composites with answers) and report a full decomposition by help type, retaining answers — now explicitly justified against the experimental reciprocity literature — as the headline outcome; (iii) model response time flexibly with discrete bins and test the answer-quality confound directly, both pooled and within bins; (iv) add robustness analyses for observable selection, entry-cohort heterogeneity (pre-2020 subsample), and churn-related selection bounds; (v) report absolute effect sizes (absolute risk differences and numbers-needed-to-treat) alongside hazard ratios; and (vi) substantially moderate the framing throughout, separating the behavioral estimates from the psychological mechanisms the data do not measure and adding dedicated limitations on external validity and the post-2022 generative-AI disruption of the platform. In the course of the re-analysis we also strengthened the matching itself, adding observable question and author characteristics to the propensity model and exact matching on the number of tags, and re-estimated all models on the resulting sample.

The manuscript remains an original contribution that is not under consideration elsewhere, and all authors have approved this revised version. We declare no competing interests. Alongside the revised manuscript we enclose the point-by-point response to reviewers, a marked summary of changes, the Highlights file, the title page, and the declaration of competing interests.

We hope the revised manuscript now meets the expectations of the reviewers and the journal,

and we would be glad to provide any further analyses or clarifications.

Sincerely,

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